Just over a decade ago, the Pulitzer-winning writer Jhumpa Lahiri, known for books like *The Namesake* and *The Interpreter of Maladies* depicting the lives of Indian immigrants in America, announced that she had moved to Rome and started writing in Italian. Her first Italian-language work arrived in 2015, titled *In altre parole* (translated into English by Ann Goldstein the following year as *In Other Words*). Since then, Lahiri has published a novel and a short story collection in Italian; a translated version of the latter was published in 2023 by Penguin Random House under the title *Roman Stories*. She has also compiled, edited and translated *The Penguin Book of Italian Short Stories*. Lahiri is, therefore, part of a very small club of major-league writers who also worked in a different language: Milan Kundera, Vladimir Nabokov, Fernando Pessoa, Samuel Beckett et al.

"The Italians were extremely supportive," Lahiri recalls during an interview in Delhi. "Without their support, I wouldn't have been able to write these books (in Italian). In fact I faced much more fear and trepidation from the Anglosphere, to be honest. People would say, 'Are you absolutely sure you want to do this?' Whereas the Italians themselves, their reaction would be quite constructive, it would be along the lines of 'Let's have your contribution to all these conversations that we're having'."

Lahiri is currently working (alongside her colleague, the classicist Yelena Baraz) on a new translation of Ovid's classic narrative poem *The Metamorphoses*, one of the most influential works in the western canon. This Latin poem is a kind of frenetic, super-condensed history of the ancient world, from the moment of Creation up until the demise of Julius Caesar. Its footprints can be observed across the very history of English literature. Ovid's account of Midas can be seen nestled within 'The Wife of Bath's Tale' from Chaucer's *The Canterbury Tales*. In the Shakespeare play *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, there's a scene where a band of actors enact moments from the lives of the lovers Thisbe and Pyramus (featured in *The Metamorphoses*); this was the same romantic pairing that inspired *Romeo and Juliet* as well. Among contemporary writers, Ali Smith used Ovid's myth of Iphis as the basis for her excellent 2007 novel *Girl Meets Boy*.

"Ever since I discovered *The Metamorphoses* in college, it has meant so much to me," says Lahiri. "Back then, the connections that I was making with the Latin text involved English. But Latin is much closer to Italian than it is to English. Ever since receiving the gift of Italian, my relationship with *The Metamorphoses* has been transformed. I don't

LAHIRI AND BARAZ'S TRANSLATION OF *THE METAMORPHOSES* SEEKS TO BRING IT INTO THE MODERN ERA



CLASSICAL ATTITUDE Gian Lorenzo Bernini's 'Apollo and Daphne' (1625), based on an episode in Ovid's *The Metamorphoses*